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If They Feel You, They'll Fund You: The Emotional Blueprint of Modern Branding

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People don't just remember ads. They remember how a brand made them feel.

— Motolani Akinyemi

They Put My Name on a Bottle — And Suddenly, I Belonged

In 2011, Coca-Cola quietly disrupted the rules of advertising. They launched the "Share a Coke" campaign, swapping their iconic logo with common first names. No new flavor. No new formula. Just your name, on a bottle.

And it worked — not because the soda changed, but because the story did.

Suddenly, people were scanning store shelves like treasure hunters. Looking for themselves. For their friends. For that girl they liked in accounting. People didn't just buy Coke. They documented it. They gifted it. They posted it. They remembered it.

Because here's the truth: people don't just buy products. They buy recognition. Connection. Belonging.

The campaign spread like memory. And in a world of algorithmic feeds and faceless brands, the most revolutionary thing a business can do... is feel personal.

What Makes a Brand Feel Like Home?

Sometimes it's not the logo. Or the slogan. Or even the product itself.

Sometimes it's the feeling. That recognition, the whisper of "this was made with me in mind."

When Ami Colé launched its debut campaign, it wasn't just the products that got people talking. It was the images. Deep, unfiltered skin tones. Glossy lips on textured hair. The warm hue of Senegalese sunsets woven into every shot. For many in the diaspora, it felt like something clicked. A beauty brand that didn't feel like it was translating us, but speaking in our native emotional tongue.

When Mented Cosmetics hit the market with nude lipsticks that didn't assume "nude" meant beige, the beauty world shifted.

They weren’t begging to be seen. They were seeing us. Their message wasn’t “we included you.”

It was “we built this for you.” That’s the difference.

And when Telfar dropped its shopping bag with the tagline “Not for you – for everyone,” the message cut across fashion, class, and community. For many in Black and queer circles, it wasn’t just a bag. It was a declaration. Style without gatekeeping. Belonging without begging.

Even in food branding, the pattern repeats. When A Dozen Cousins hit shelves with their bold, culturally-rooted flavors and clean packaging, West African and Caribbean diaspora communities responded instantly. It didn’t just taste like home, it looked like it respected it.

This wasn’t branding. It was remembrance.

It was the power of seeing your story—your palette, your slang, your grandma’s okra soup, reflected back at you in a product that felt earned, not extracted.

And here’s what matters: these brands didn’t need a $500k marketing budget to connect. They needed truth. Resonance. A willingness to build with clarity and care.

Because no matter how loud the world gets, the brands we carry in our hearts are the ones that made us feel something first.

Story as Strategy — Not Fluff

Some people still treat storytelling like a bonus. Something you add to your pitch deck last minute or sprinkle on top of your website copy like parsley.

But here’s the truth: story is not seasoning. It’s substance.

It’s what makes a stranger stay long enough to listen. It is what turns browsers into buyers. It’s what convinces someone to spend more, not because they have to, but because they want to believe in what you’re building.

In branding, story isn’t a sweet detail. It’s a strategic asset.

They know that a compelling story shapes perception, builds trust, and turns first-time buyers into lifelong believers. Even the tiniest touchpoints matter. A post-purchase email that says, "We're proud to be part of your journey." A UX message that reads, "You're almost there. We're cheering you on."

Emotional UX copy is strategy with heart. It makes a product feel like a promise.

When You’re the Brand: Letting Your Voice Speak

It’s not enough to be visible. People want vibe + value.

Today, more founders are stepping out from behind the logo and leading with personal voice. Not as a performance, but as a presence. And it works.

Arlan Hamilton, the force behind Backstage Capital, didn’t build her brand on polished perfection. She built it on truth; homelessness, ambition, tenacity, and her audience didn’t just fund her. They followed

Your voice isn’t a distraction. It’s the differentiator. When you lead with clarity and conviction, you create resonance. And that resonance turns into revenue.

Design That Says What Words Can’t

Visual branding speaks before your copy does. Fonts, colors, and packaging tell a story, whether you mean them to or not.

Brands that understand this don’t just look good — they feel intentional.

Take Ami Colé. Their minimalist design, warm tones, and melanin-first focus don’t scream for attention. They whisper, You belong here.

Or consider Golde. Their soft yellows and playful illustrations make wellness feel approachable, not elite.

Design is more than aesthetic. It's access. It invites or excludes. It calms or overwhelms. And when it's done right, it remembers the audience it was built for.

Feeling Before Funding: What Investors Are Actually Buying

Let’s be clear: Investors care about numbers. About margins, strategy, scalability. Logic absolutely matters. But logic alone doesn’t close the deal.

Because at the end of the day, business is still human.

Behind every pitch deck is a person, a purpose, a voice. And in a crowded world, the brands that win are the ones that make people feel something, not just think something.

More and more, we’re seeing investors respond not just to polished models, but to clarity. Alignment. Story. A founder who knows exactly who they’re serving, and why it matters.

That emotional connection doesn’t replace logic. It supports it. It brings the business to life.

Take Fenty Beauty, for example. On paper, it’s a cosmetics line: high-quality formulations, bold packaging, impressive sales. That’s the logic. But what made Fenty a cultural reset, and an investor’s dream, was what it represented.

When Rihanna launched with 40 foundation shades and campaign visuals that embraced everyone from hijabi models to queer Black men, she wasn’t just selling makeup. She was telling millions, “You were never the afterthought. You are the market.”

That feeling? That belonging? You can’t get that just anywhere. And you can’t ignore it.

It’s why people repost campaigns, wait for drops, build loyalty beyond logic. Because the story connects, and the product delivers.

So yes, have your projections tight. Know your growth levers. Be pitch-deck ready.

But never forget: the numbers explain how your business works. The story explains why it matters.

And the “why” is often what people remember long after the spreadsheet is closed.

More pitch decks are opening with why instead of what. Because heart-led brands are easier to trust. And in a world full of options, trust is the only currency that matters.

Whether you're selling handmade soap or launching a tech platform, the question isn't just how do I get funded? It's how do I make them feel?

Build What You Needed to See

Your brand is a mirror. If you’re trying to resonate with others, start by telling the truth about what you needed, what you never saw, what you still wish existed.

Branding isn’t about manipulation. It’s memory. And memory makes money.

If you build from your roots, speak with your own voice, and treat emotion like an asset, you won’t have to beg people to buy. You’ll remind them why they believed in you in the first place.

Because if they feel you, they’ll fund you. But first, you have to feel yourself.

Why This Lives Here

Makolaa is a home for creative entrepreneurs who are rewriting what branding means. We believe in business that moves, touches, and reflects. This story is a reminder that clarity, community, and emotional connection aren’t nice-to-haves. They’re how we win.